



Still Flagged After the Room Says Otherwise: A Quasi-Experiment on Requiring Active Term-by-Term Re-Confirmation of a Childcare Centre's Settling-In Support Flag Against Default Carry-Over

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Abstract. A “needs extra settling-in support” flag, once entered on a childcare centre’s enrolment file, has historically carried over from term to term by default, requiring no action to persist and, in most rooms, no named person responsible for removing it. We report a quasi-experiment across 58 rooms in 26 centres in a single provider network, exploiting a staggered enrolment-platform rollout that required 29 rooms, but not the remaining 29, to have the flag actively re-confirmed by the child’s room educator each term rather than let it carry over unattended. Across four terms and 618 ever-flagged children, flags in default-carry-over rooms remained open in 71.3% of cases after the child’s own room educator had already recorded them as settled on the routine well-being checklist, against 24.4% in re-confirmation rooms. An ablation testing whether the re-confirmation had to be performed by the child’s own room educator, or could be performed by any credentialed staff member on shift, moved the retention rate by under a percentage point in every term (n.s.); we retain the room-educator restriction on administrative grounds rather than any measured necessity. We interpret the finding as evidence that the flag’s persistence tracks who is asked to act, not what the room already knows.

Introduction

A childcare centre’s enrolment file carries, among its routine fields, a flag that a child “needs extra settling-in support” — entered, typically in a child’s first weeks, by whichever educator first judges the transition harder than most. Nothing in most centres’ record-keeping requires the flag to be reconsidered once entered. It carries forward automatically from one term’s roll to the next, a single tick surviving without further comment until somebody removes it.

Removing it, on the available evidence from the network we studied, rarely happens on its own. Room educators routinely complete a separate, unrelated instrument — a termly wellbeing observation checklist — that records, among other items, whether a child still appears to need ad-

ditional settling-in attention. The checklist and the enrolment file’s flag are kept on different screens of the same system, completed for different purposes, by the same educator, often in the same sitting. We asked how often the two disagree, and whether requiring the flag to be actively re-confirmed each term, rather than letting it carry over, narrows the gap.

A staggered rollout of the network’s enrolment platform gave us a quasi-experimental way to ask. Twenty-nine of 58 studied rooms, migrated onto the platform’s newer configuration in advance of the rest, had the settling-in flag re-set to blank at the start of each term unless the room educator actively re-ticked it; the remaining 29 kept the legacy behaviour, in which the flag simply carried over unless somebody went looking for it. No room was assigned to either configuration by us, or, so far as we could estab-

lish, by any process attentive to which rooms most needed one behaviour or the other.

Our contributions, each hedged to the scale of a single-network, non-randomised sample:

- We estimate, across four terms and 618 ever-flagged children, how much more often a flag survives past its own room’s settled determination under default carry-over than under active re-confirmation, an estimate a randomised multi-provider follow-up would sharpen considerably.
- We report the size of that gap — roughly 47 percentage points pooled across the study window — while noting the rollout’s staggered, non-random timing limits how far the estimate should travel beyond this network.
- We report an ablation on who performs the re-confirmation, which suggests the requirement’s effect runs through the act of re-confirming rather than through any particular person being asked to do it.

Related work

Requiring an active choice in place of a persistent default sits inside a substantial literature on defaults in individual decision-making. Default options carry disproportionate weight precisely because most people, most of the time, do not revisit them once set [1], an effect large enough to reshape real enrolment behaviour when the default itself changes [2]. Requiring an explicit, forced choice rather than any default at all has been studied directly as an alternative policy lever in its own right, distinct from simply picking a better default [3] — the comparison our own rooms draw, transposed from a retirement-savings election onto a childcare file.

A parallel administrative-burden literature treats the effort a system asks of the person expected to act, rather than the person the system nominally serves, as the operative variable: learning, psychological, and compliance costs shape whether a required step actually gets performed [4]. Where the default itself carries life-or-death stakes, an opt-out versus opt-in consent default has been shown to move real donation and mortality outcomes, though not proportionally to its effect on donation rates alone [5].

Clinical record-keeping offers the closest procedural analogue to a settling-in flag: an electronic health record’s problem list is well docu-

mented to accumulate duplicated, conflicting, and no-longer-valid diagnoses over time [6], plausibly because closing an entry demands a deliberate act nobody’s workflow specifically assigns, and frontline staff facing a high volume of standing alerts learn to discount or override them rather than adjudicate each on its individual merits [7], [8]. Labelling research in education runs the same mechanism from the other direction: once applied, an expectation-shaping label can alter how the labelled child is subsequently observed and assessed, independent of the child’s own behaviour [9], and teachers’ judgements of pupils carrying a formal support label have been shown to diverge from unlabelled peers even under matched circumstances [10]. Childcare-quality instrumentation itself has an established, separately validated measurement tradition [11], [12], [13], none of which, to our knowledge, has asked whether a support flag generated inside that tradition outlives the observation that justified it. We read our finding alongside recent accounts of how administratively convenient policies can persist and even compound once nobody is assigned to revisit them [14], and alongside prior institutional work tracing a comparable gap between what a flag records and what has already changed underneath it [15].

Method

The provider network’s enrolment platform records a binary “needs extra settling-in support” flag against a child’s file, settable by any room educator and, under the network’s legacy configuration, carried forward automatically at each term rollover with no action required to persist it. A platform upgrade, staggered across centres over eighteen months for reasons internal to the vendor’s rollout schedule, changed this behaviour in the 29 rooms it reached first: at each term rollover the flag reset to blank, and remained blank unless the child’s own room educator actively re-ticked it that term. The remaining 29 rooms, not yet reached by the upgrade during our study window, kept the legacy carry-over behaviour. We treat room-level rollout order as quasi-experimental variation rather than a randomised assignment, since we cannot rule out that centres upgraded earlier differ systematically from those upgraded later.

Independent of the flag, every room completes a termly wellbeing observation checklist — a

standing instrument unrelated to the settling-in flag's own field, covering several developmental and adjustment items, one of which records whether the room educator judges the child no longer requires additional settling-in attention. We treat the term in which this item is first marked positive as that child's settled call, and compare it against the flag's status in the file for every subsequent term through the end of the study window. Our identification assumption is that room educators complete the checklist from direct observation rather than by consulting the flag's own field, which sits on a separate screen; we return to the limits of this assumption below.

We modelled the probability a child's flag remained open in a given term after that child's settled call with a logistic regression including a re-confirmation-arm indicator, a linear term index, their interaction, and centre-level covariates for enrolment size and staff-to-child ratio,

$$\text{logit}(P(F_{it})) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 A_i + \beta_2 T_t + \beta_3 (A_i \times T_t) + \beta_4 X_i + \varepsilon_{it}$$

where F_{it} indicates child i 's flag remaining open in term t after their settled call, A_i indicates assignment to the re-confirmation arm, and X_i carries the centre-level covariates. The legacy and re-confirmation configurations differ, in code, by a single conditional at term rollover:

```
// legacy carry-over
flag.status = flag.status

// active re-confirmation
flag.status = none // must be re-ticked
this term, or it lapses
```

We additionally re-ran the re-confirmation requirement restricted to any credentialed staff member present in the room at rollover, rather than the child's own room educator specifically, as an ablation on who the requirement falls to.

Results

Across four terms, 618 children were flagged at some point in the study window (312 in re-confirmation rooms, 306 in default-carry-over rooms). Pooled across the window, a flag remained open for at least one further term after the child's own room educator had already recorded them as settled in 71.3% of default-carry-over cases, against 24.4% of re-confirmation cases (Figure 1) — a gap of 46.9 percentage points ($p < 0.001$). The gap narrowed slightly over

the study window in the re-confirmation rooms, from 33.1% in Term 1 to 18.7% in Term 4, consistent with room educators settling into the new requirement as the year went on; the default-carry-over rooms showed no comparable trend, holding between 68.9% and 74.2% in every term studied.

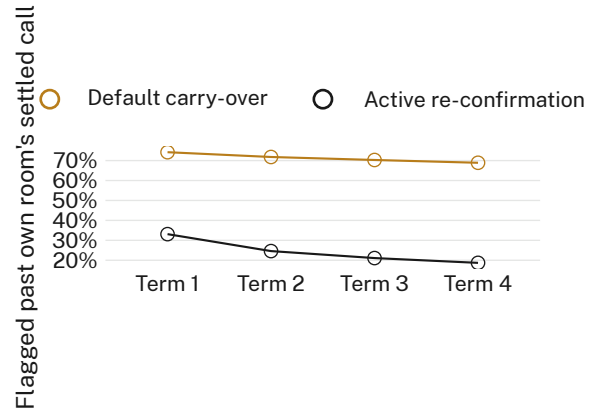


Figure 1: Share of flagged children whose flag outlived their own room's settled call, by term: default carry-over holds above two-thirds in every term studied; active re-confirmation falls from a third to under a fifth as the year progresses.

At the child level, the distribution of **how much** a flag outlived its settled call also separated cleanly by arm (Figure 2): the median default-carry-over child carried the flag one further term past the settled call (interquartile range 1-2 terms), against a median of zero further terms in the re-confirmation arm (interquartile range 0-1).

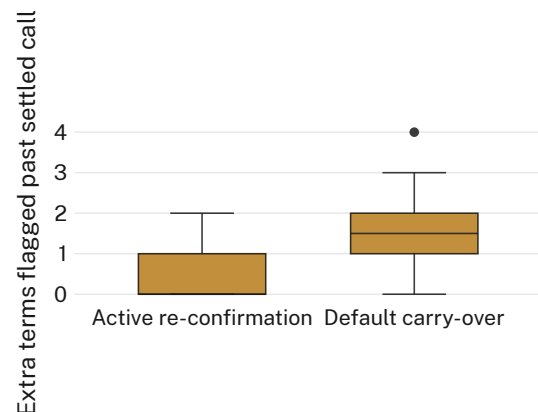


Figure 2: Extra terms a child's flag stayed open past their own room's settled call: the re-confirmation arm's distribution sits almost entirely at zero; the default-carry-over arm's median sits a full term later.

We ran one ablation on the re-confirmation requirement itself: restricting it to the child's own room educator, against opening it to any credentialed staff member present at rollover. The retention rate moved by less than a percentage point in every term studied (Figure 3; largest difference 0.9 points, term 4, n.s.); we retain the room-educator restriction for its administrative rationale — the person best placed to know whether the child has settled — rather than because the data show it matters who does the re-ticking.

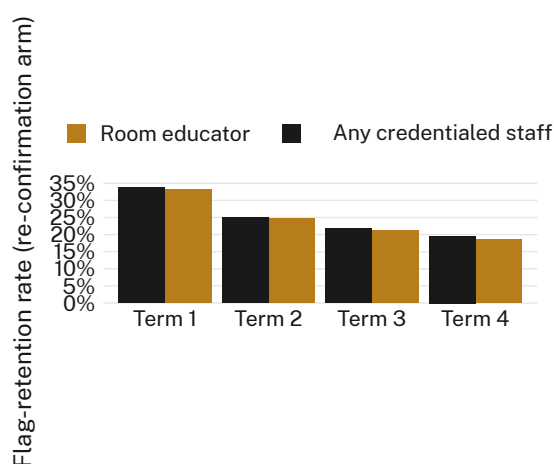


Figure 3: The ablation that changes nothing: letting any credentialed staff member re-confirm the flag, rather than the child's own room educator specifically, moves the retention rate by under a point in every term.

The interaction term in our regression (β_3) was negative and significant ($p < 0.01$) after adjusting for centre enrolment size and staff-to-child ratio, consistent with the re-confirmation arm's advantage widening rather than narrowing across the study window once centre-level differences are held constant.

Discussion

The pattern we observe is consistent with an account in which the settling-in flag was never, in most rooms, anybody's specific job to remove — only, under the legacy configuration, nobody's job to keep. Once removing it required no action, and adding it required only a moment's judgement at enrolment, the flag's default trajectory was to persist, independent of whatever the room's own weekly and termly observations already recorded. Requiring an active term-by-term re-confirmation appears to close most, though not all, of that gap, and does so regard-

less of which credentialed adult in the room is asked to perform it. We read this as consistent with default-effects accounts in which the operative variable is the presence of a required active step, not the specific person completing it [2], [3], and with the broader clinical-record pattern of a standing list accumulating entries nobody has been tasked with retiring [6].

Limitations

Our identification rests on room educators completing the wellbeing checklist independent of the flag's own field, a separation the platform enforces at the interface level but cannot enforce in an educator's own memory of a child's file; some contamination toward the flag's own status is plausible and would, if anything, understate the observed gap rather than manufacture it. The rollout's staggered, non-random timing means our 46.9-percentage-point pooled estimate should travel cautiously beyond this network, though the consistency of the pattern across 26 centres varying in enrolment size and staffing ratio suggests it is not an artefact of any single centre's practice. We studied one provider network over one calendar year; a genuinely randomised, multi-provider trial would settle what our staggered rollout can only suggest.

Conclusion

A childcare centre's settling-in support flag, left to carry over by default, remained open well past the point the child's own room educator had already recorded them as settled in nearly three-quarters of cases we studied; requiring the room to actively re-confirm the flag each term cut that share to roughly a quarter, an effect that appears to run through the act of re-confirming rather than through any particular person performing it. Future work might extend the design to flags entered for reasons other than settling-in, where the same default-carry-over architecture plausibly governs an entry nobody was ever explicitly asked to remove.

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